

A Register of Record and Inference

What Culin saw, what he was told, and what he concluded — kept apart, part by part.

LXX–LXXIII · part The games of chance

WHAT CULIN RECORDS

The nyout board and its four throwing sticks, described from the inside: twenty-nine marks, twenty in a circle and nine in an interior cross, drawn on paper or scratched in the ground; the names of the throws; two, three or four players; and the flat statement that it is “the most popular game in Korea at the present day”. With it the game of promotion played on a printed chart of official ranks, the dice, and *ssang-ryouk*, which is backgammon. Culin also gives the seasons: nyout belongs to the new year, and he reports it played by adults in the street as well as by children, which is the kind of detail that fixes a game in a society rather than in a catalogue.

WHAT HE IS TOLD

The Chinese and Japanese parallels, taken from Culin’s other informants and from books — the Chinese dice with the red one-spot and four-spot, the substitution of a die for the four staves. These are as good as the sources he names, and he names them.

WHAT HE CONCLUDES

That the four staves are divining arrows in another form, and that the board’s circle-and-cross is the world quarters. This is the theory, applied.

HOW TO READ IT

Read the nyout chapter as the best thing in the book. It is the fullest first-hand description of a Korean game printed in English in the nineteenth century, and none of it depends on where the sticks came from. Nyout is still played; it is *yut* or *yunnori* now, and it is still a new-year game. The one thing to supply is the number of men a side, which varies with the number of players in his account and is the only place his description leaves you stuck.

LXXIV–LXXV · part The two great board games

WHAT CULIN RECORDS

Korean chess by **W. H. Wilkinson**, who had been acting consul-general at Seoul and had played it: the board’s files carried across the river so that the river is ignored, the king placed in the centre of his palace, the men octagonal rather than round and graded in size by value. And *pa-tok*, which is go, on a board Culin reports as far larger than a chessboard and reckoned by its intersections. And the handicap conventions for pa-tok, which are the hardest part of nineteenth-century go practice to find anywhere else.

WHAT HE IS TOLD

The identification of pa-tok with Chinese *wei-ch’i* and Japanese go, which is correct and uncontroversial, and the derivation of Korean chess from the Chinese game, which is also correct.

WHAT HE CONCLUDES

That both descend from divinatory practice on a diagram of the world quarters. Not held. It is worth noticing that Culin does not push the theory hard here. The two chapters where his informants knew most are the two where he theorises least, which is either modesty or the evidence resisting.

HOW TO READ IT

Wilkinson’s chapter is the one place in the volume where the author had played the game he is describing, and it reads differently for it — shorter, harder, less interested in origins. It is also a separate authorship: Wilkinson (1858–1930) signs it, and this edition keeps his name on it.

LXXVI–LXXX · part Lines and squares

WHAT CULIN RECORDS

The kono family — well kono, four-field, five-field, six-field — and *kon-tjil*, which is merrells. Small diagram games played on scratched lines with pebbles or beans, each described in a paragraph or two. Well kono is the pick of them: a blocking game for two men a side in which the object is to leave your opponent with no move, learnable in a minute and genuinely good.

WHAT HE IS TOLD

The correspondences with Chinese and Japanese line games.

WHAT HE CONCLUDES

That the diagram is a cosmological figure before it is a board.

HOW TO READ IT

The shortest entries in the volume and the most fragile evidence, because a line game leaves nothing behind. What Culin gives here is a snapshot of what children and idlers were playing in the 1890s, which is exactly the material that usually goes unrecorded.

LXXXI–LXXXIX · part The tablets

WHAT CULIN RECORDS

Korean dominoes — *kol-hpai*, “bone tablets”, or *ho-hpai*, “foreign tablets”, the second said to be the more correct name — with the games played on them, the solitaires, and the divining procedures: dragon tablets, tortoise tablets, and *sin-syo-tyem*, “personally counting divination”. With the games’ own names, which do half the work: *kol-hpai*, bone tablets, from the material; *ho-hpai*, foreign tablets, from where they came from.

WHAT HE IS TOLD

The Chinese domino sets and their game names, from Culin’s Chinese informants and from Wilkinson.

WHAT HE CONCLUDES

That the divining use is the original and the game the residue — the clearest statement of the whole thesis, because here the two forms genuinely do sit side by side.

HOW TO READ IT

This is where Culin’s case is strongest and where it is worth being most careful. That a set of tablets is used both to play and to divine is an observation; that the divining came first is an inference, and the same tablets would look the same either way round.

XC–XCII · part The cards

WHAT CULIN RECORDS

The Korean pack: long narrow strips of oiled paper, eight suits of ten, eighty cards and a spare blank, the backs uniformly marked, the suits named — man, fish, crow, pheasant, antelope, star, rabbit, horse. A pack in the United States National Museum is described specimen by specimen. The suits are named for man, fish, crow, pheasant, antelope, star, rabbit and horse — a list worth keeping because the pack itself has gone out of use and this is one of the few full descriptions of it.

WHAT HE IS TOLD

The Chinese and Japanese card games, and the comparison of the Korean suits with the Chinese “money” suits.

WHAT HE CONCLUDES

That the cards are divining arrows: the strips carry a conventionalised feather, and the Chinese name differs from the word for arrow only in tone. This is the load-bearing claim of the whole book.

HOW TO READ IT

The feather and the tone are real observations and the conclusion drawn from them is a leap. Keep them apart and the chapter is a fine description of a pack no longer in use; run them together and it is an origin story the evidence will not carry.

XCIII–XCVII · part The lottery and the word games

WHAT CULIN RECORDS

San-htong, the lottery, and with it the *kyei* — the money-lending clubs of ten, twenty, fifty, a hundred or a thousand members, each contributing at fixed intervals and drawing by lot until every member has had their own back. Drawn with wooden balls the size of marbles, or hazel nuts. Then the riddles and word games that close the book.

WHAT HE IS TOLD

The Chinese lottery, its eighty written lots, and the practice of throwing eighty numbered arrow-lots at a shrine of the God of War to divine the lucky numbers.

WHAT HE CONCLUDES

That the lottery is the arrow-divination surviving whole, and its Korean name gives it away.

HOW TO READ IT

The *kyei* passage is the most valuable page in this part and has nothing to do with games: it is a description of a rotating savings association, recorded incidentally because the lottery grew out of it. Culin’s theory brought him to it, which is the argument for taking Victorian theories seriously even when they are wrong. The *kyei* is now called *gye* and the institution is still alive; rotating savings and credit associations of exactly this shape are documented across the world and are a serious subject in development economics. Culin got to one in 1895 by following an arrow.